

Thermal-neutron statistics for X17 production at n_TOF EAR2

What 4×10^8 fully simulated neutrons say about the sub-keV rate tables

Dylan Neff

11 June 2026

Internal note — informal. Drafted by Claude (Anthropic AI assistant) under D. Neff’s direction; simulation, numbers and text reviewed by D. Neff.

PRELIMINARY: based on 40 of 100 run-B jobs (4×10^8 of 10^9 neutrons);
remaining statistics in production, no qualitative change expected.

Part I — Summary

The question

The X17 search at EAR2 produces its signal through radiative neutron capture: a slow neutron absorbed by ^3He forms $^4\text{He}^*$ at 20.6 MeV, and that de-excitation is the only doorway to X17 (or to the internal-pair background, IPC). The expected event rate per proton pulse therefore scales directly with the number of *radiative* captures per pulse. The collaboration rate table (`calculation.tables/results_3He`) quotes 1.2×10^{-2} IPC/pulse from neutrons below 1 keV — the number that anchored the $3.0\sigma/30$ -day sensitivity projection.

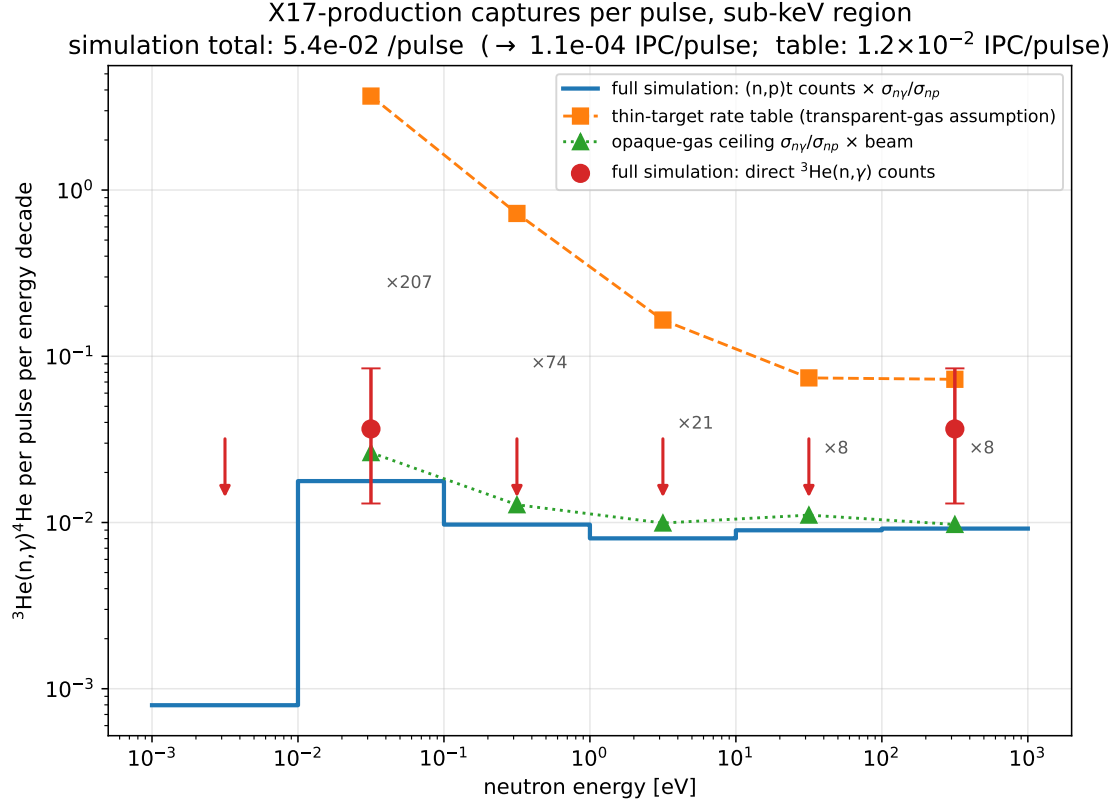
The problem

That table computes the radiative-capture probability as (target thickness) $\times$ (cross-section), which silently assumes neutrons fly through the gas undisturbed. They do not. At thermal energy the competing $^3\text{He}(n,p)t$ reaction gives a neutron a mean free path of ~ 0.15 mm, against 60 mm of gas along the beam axis (on-axis optical depth ~ 400): **the gas is opaque**. Every sub-keV neutron is absorbed regardless of the gas thickness, so the rare radiative branch cannot exceed its share of the total, $\sigma_{n\gamma}/\sigma_{np} = 1.0 \times 10^{-8}$ per absorbed neutron — no matter how much gas is added. The thin-target formula overshoots this ceiling by a factor equal to the gas opacity: $\times 8$ to $\times 200$ depending on energy.

What we did

Run B of the Geant4 campaign fired 10^9 neutrons (this draft: the first validated 4×10^8) at the full STEP-derived capsule geometry, with energies drawn from the evaluated EAR2 flux and transverse positions from the energy-dependent beam profile, using high-precision neutron data (G4NDL). Self-shielding, scattering, beam halo and geometry are then automatic — no analytic assumption. Every neutron’s terminal interaction (volume, process, position, energy) was recorded.

The answer



The full simulation (blue curve, with the four directly observed radiative captures as red points) lands on the opaque-gas ceiling (green) and confirms the rate table (orange) is too optimistic by $\times 8$ – 200 per decade. Folding in the beam spectrum:

	rate table	full simulation
radiative captures / pulse ($E_n < 1$ keV)	5.8	5.4×10^{-2}
IPC / pulse	1.21×10^{-2}	1.14×10^{-4}
X17 / pulse (2.5% assumed)	—	1.4×10^{-3}

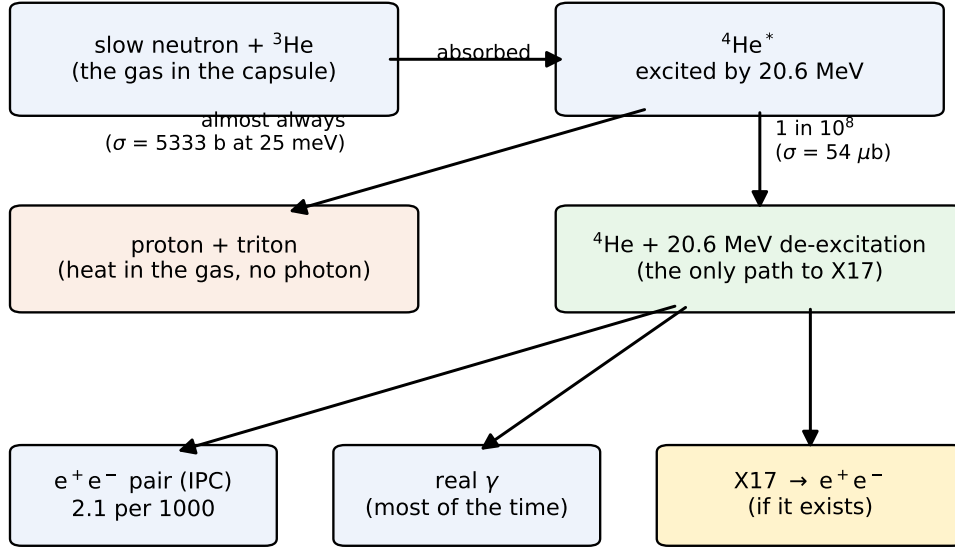
The sub-keV statistics are a factor ~ 106 below the table. If the sensitivity projection is anchored to the sub-keV rows, the $3.0\sigma/30$ d becomes $\sim 0.3\sigma/30$ d. The physical rate is not gone, however: above ~ 100 keV the gas really is thin and the table is valid there; those rows carry $\sim 98\%$ of the total radiative captures. The likely conclusion is that **the analysis region of interest must move to the 0.1–10 MeV region**, which changes the generator kinematics and the gamma-flash/TOF situation — to be discussed with Alberto (run B-full, 1 meV–100 MeV, is already on disk for this).

Part II — The full story, from the beginning

1 What can happen when a slow neutron meets ^3He

When the neutron is absorbed, the compound nucleus $^4\text{He}^*$ holds 20.6 MeV of excitation energy. It almost always sheds it by breaking into a proton and a triton — a quiet outcome that deposits heat in the gas and produces no high-energy photon. About once in 10^8 absorptions it instead de-excites electromagnetically, and only this branch can produce a real 20.6 MeV photon, an internal e^+e^- pair, or — if it exists — the X17 boson. Counting X17 statistics is therefore exactly the business of counting these rare radiative captures.

What can happen when a slow neutron meets ^3He



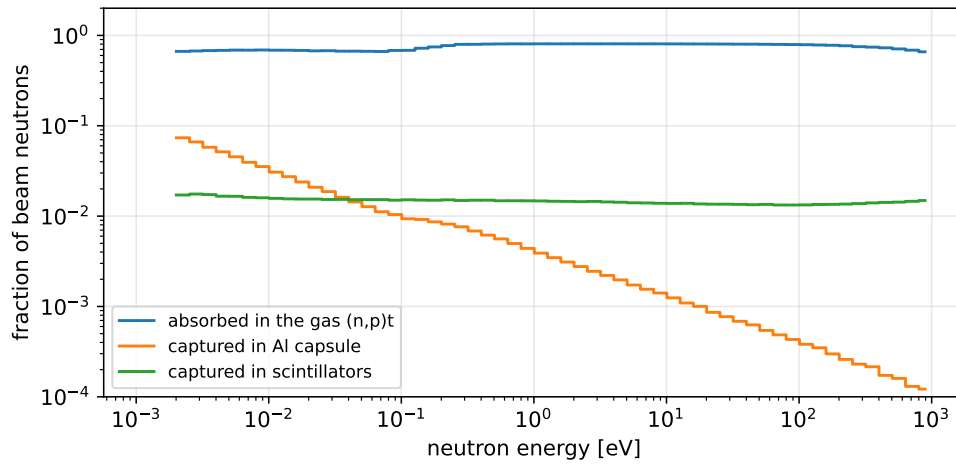
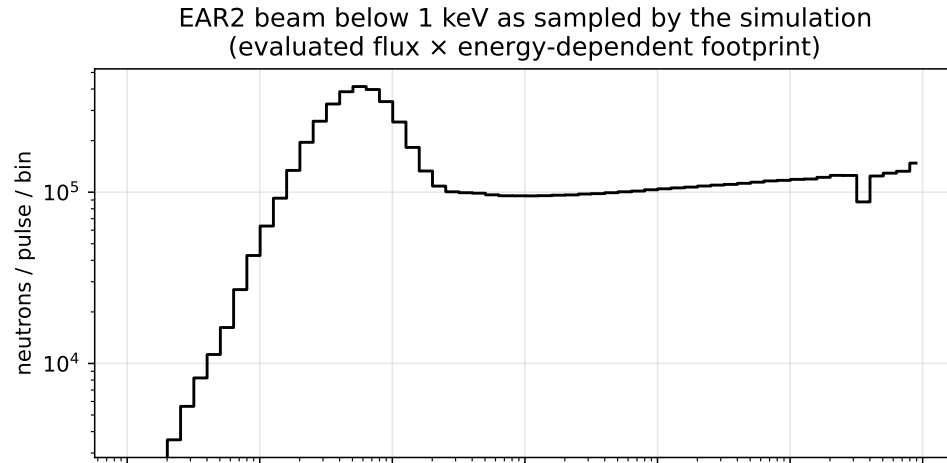
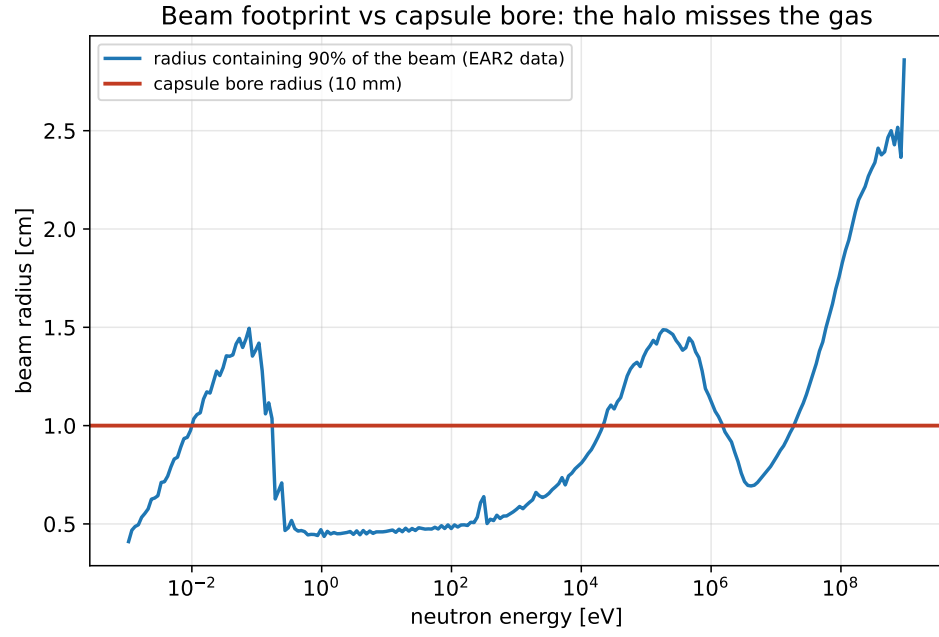
The two relevant cross-sections at thermal energy (25 meV): breakup $\sigma_{np} = 5333$ b, radiative $\sigma_{n\gamma} = 54 \mu\text{b}$. Both fall as $1/v$ with neutron speed, so their ratio,

$$\frac{\sigma_{n\gamma}}{\sigma_{np}} = \frac{54 \times 10^{-6}}{5333} = 1.0 \times 10^{-8}, \quad (1)$$

is essentially constant across the whole sub-keV region. Keep this number in mind — it is the punchline of the entire note.

2 What the beam delivers

EAR2 delivers 7.31×10^6 neutrons per proton pulse below 1 keV (evaluated Phase-3 flux). The beam is not a pencil: its transverse size grows toward low energies, while the capsule bore is only 20 mm across, so an energy-dependent fraction of the beam misses the gas entirely or hits the thick aluminium shoulder instead. The simulation samples both the energy spectrum and this energy-dependent footprint, so all acceptance effects are folded in from the start.

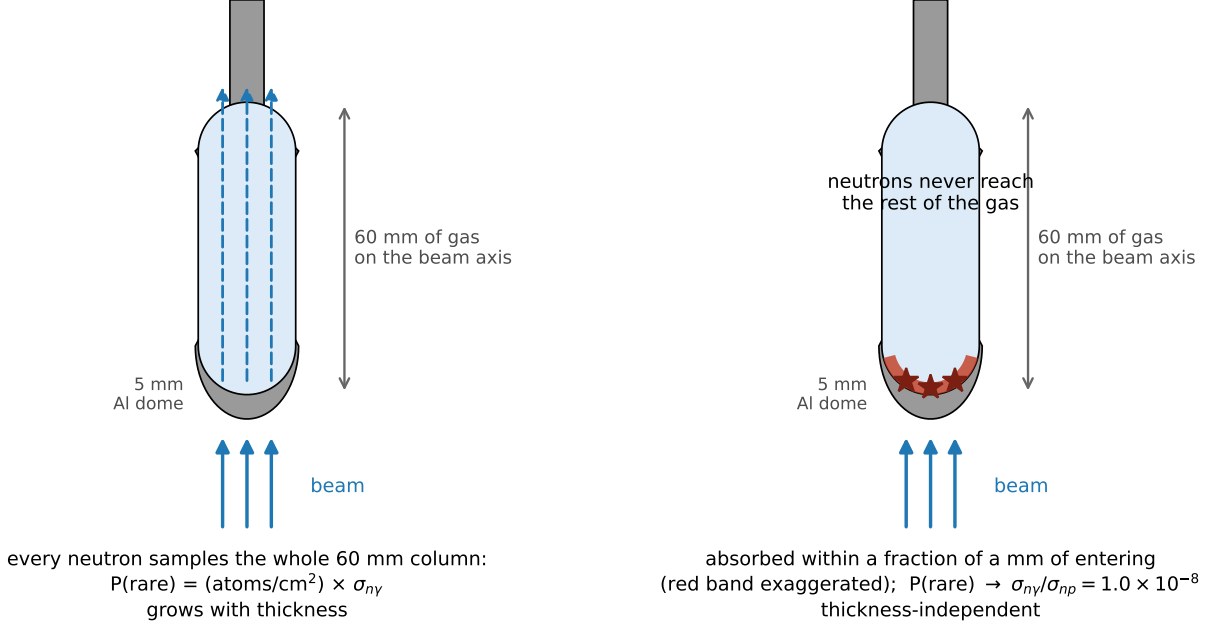


In numbers, for the sub-keV beam: 73.6% of all beam neutrons are absorbed in the gas, 23.9% leave the world without interacting (mostly footprint tail outside the bore), and the remainder is captured in surrounding material — of which more in Sec. 6.

3 The core issue: the gas is a black absorber, not a thin foil

The assumption: gas is transparent
(thin-target formula)

The reality below 1 keV: gas is opaque
(mean free path ≈ 0.15 mm at 25 meV)



The rate table computes, for each energy bin,

$$P_{\text{rad}} = nL \cdot \sigma_{n\gamma}(E), \quad (2)$$

with nL the gas column density. The table assumes $nL = 3.16 \times 10^{-2}$ atoms/b (its geometry was a 4 cm gas sphere); the real capsule presents an even thicker 60 mm on-axis column, $nL = 7.5 \times 10^{-2}$ atoms/b. This is the standard *thin-target* formula and it is correct *only* when the neutron actually traverses the full column, i.e. when $nL \sigma_{np} \ll 1$. At 25 meV, however, $nL \sigma_{np} \approx 150$ for the table's column (≈ 400 for the capsule on axis): a neutron penetrates a fraction of a millimetre before being absorbed. In that regime the probability that the absorption is radiative saturates at the branching ratio:

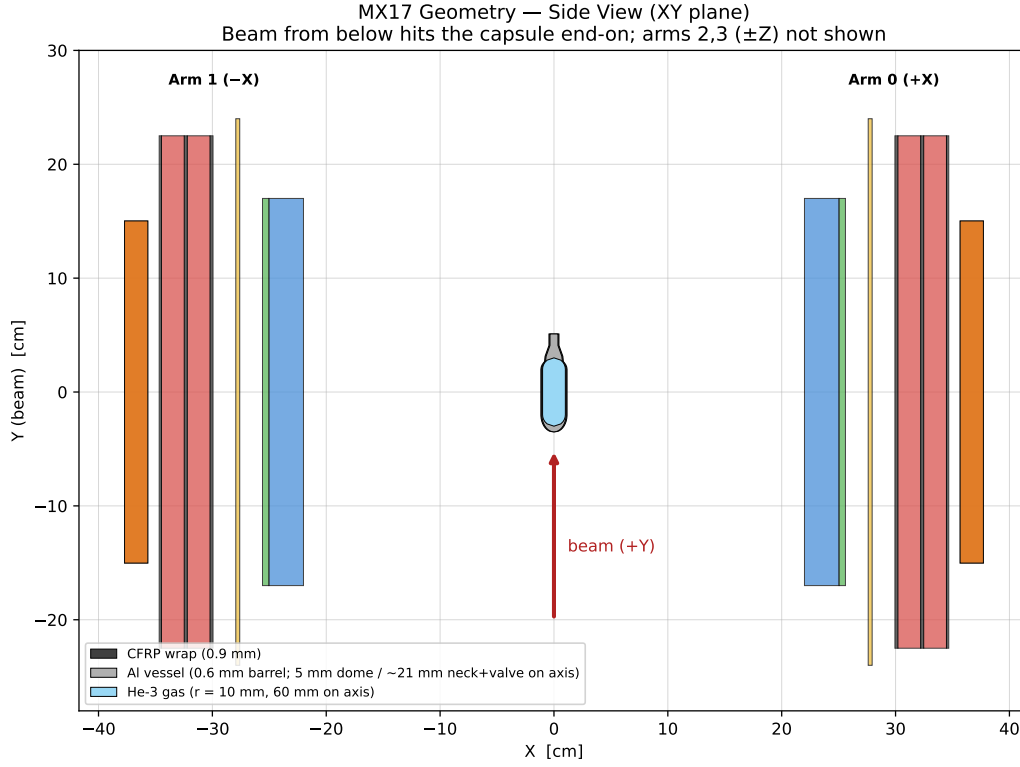
$$P_{\text{rad}} \longrightarrow \frac{\sigma_{n\gamma}}{\sigma_{np}} = 1.0 \times 10^{-8} \quad (\text{independent of } L). \quad (3)$$

Dividing Eq. (2) by Eq. (3) shows the thin-target formula overshoots by exactly the opacity $nL \sigma_{np}$ of the column it assumed — for the table, a factor 150 at thermal, falling to ~ 7 at 1 keV. Adding more gas, or pressurising further, gains nothing below 1 keV: every neutron is already absorbed, and the radiative branch can only ever win its fixed share.

4 What the full simulation adds

The cartoon argument above is one-dimensional. The real situation (Fig. below) has the beam arriving from below along the capsule axis, entering through a 5 mm-thick domed aluminium tip; the gas column length depends on where the neutron enters; the beam is wider than the bore; elastic scattering can bounce neutrons around; and the four detector arms surround the capsule transversely at 22 cm. Geant4 with high-precision neutron data (G4NDL) transports every neutron through the actual STEP-derived geometry and lets nature take its course. The

simulation records, for each of the 4×10^8 neutrons in this draft, where its track ended, by which process, and at what energy — so the capture accounting is exact, including all geometry and transport effects.

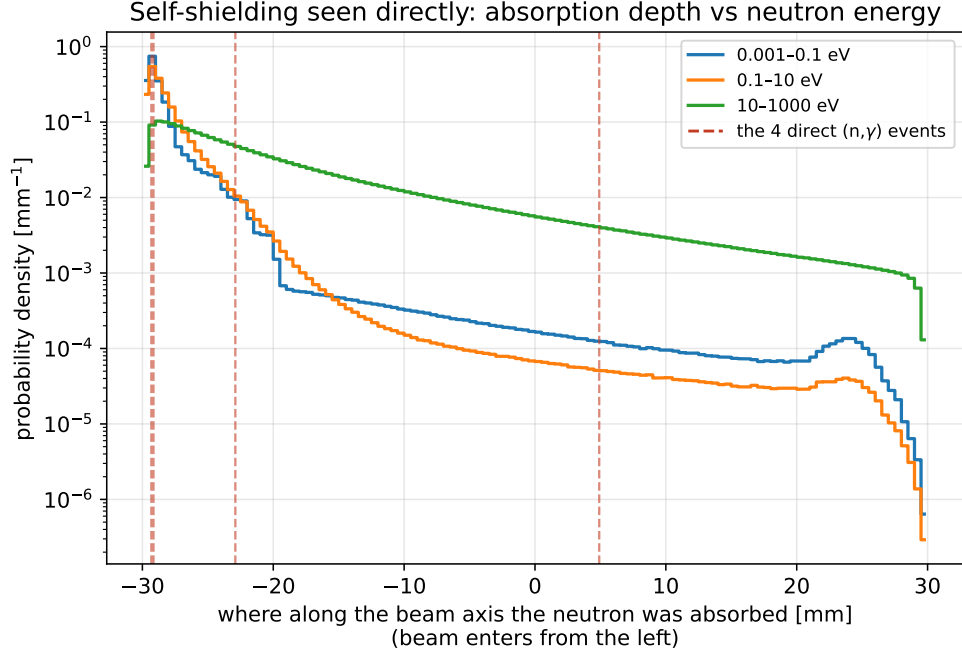


Capsule dimensions (STEP-derived): gas bore $r = 10$ mm, 60 mm long on axis (40 mm cylinder + hemispherical ends); Al wall 0.6 mm on the barrel but **5 mm on axis upstream** (dome) and **~21 mm on axis downstream** (neck + valve), plus a 0.9 mm CFRP overwrap.

5 The evidence

5.1 Self-shielding, observed directly

If the opaque-gas picture is right, thermal neutrons must pile up at the entrance face of the gas while keV neutrons penetrate deeper. That is exactly what the absorption-depth distribution shows:



Below 0.1 eV the absorption depth is a sliver at the entrance; by 0.1–1 keV it spreads through the column. The four directly observed radiative captures (dashed lines) follow the same pattern: the two thermal ones sit within a millimetre of the entrance window, the two at ~ 500 eV are distributed through the gas.

5.2 The rate, measured three ways

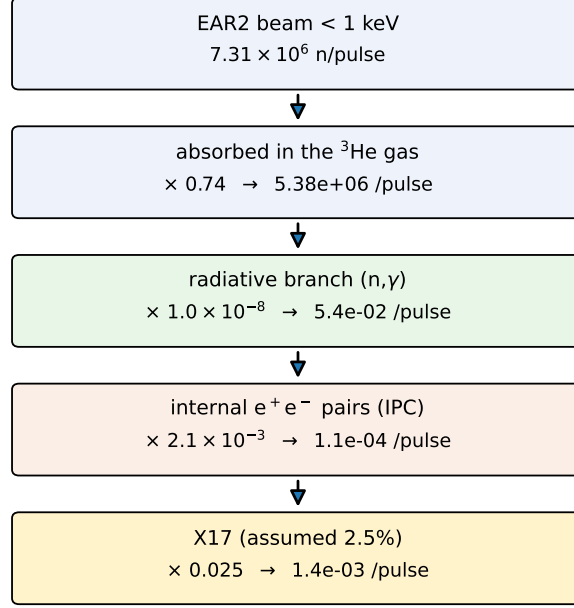
The headline figure (Part I) compares, per energy decade:

1. **Direct counts:** four ${}^3\text{He}(n,\gamma)$ events in 4×10^8 neutrons $\Rightarrow (1.0^{+0.8}_{-0.5}) \times 10^{-8}$ per beam neutron.
2. **High-statistics proxy:** 2.94×10^8 observed (n,p)t absorptions multiplied by the branching ratio of Eq. (1) — statistically exact in the opaque regime, since every absorbed neutron had the same 10^{-8} chance of taking the radiative exit instead.
3. **The analytic ceiling:** Eq. (3) times the beam.

All three agree. The rate table exceeds them by $\times 207$ (thermal decade) down to $\times 8$ (100 eV–1 keV); the row-by-row comparison is in Appendix A. As a by-product the agreement of (1) and (2) confirms that the G4NDL nuclear data contain the radiative branch at the right strength — the ratio test gives $N_{n\gamma}/N_{np} = 1.4^{+1.1}_{-0.7} \times 10^{-8}$ against the expected 1.0×10^{-8} .

5.3 From captures to X17 per pulse

Per-pulse normalisation ladder (sub-keV, full simulation)



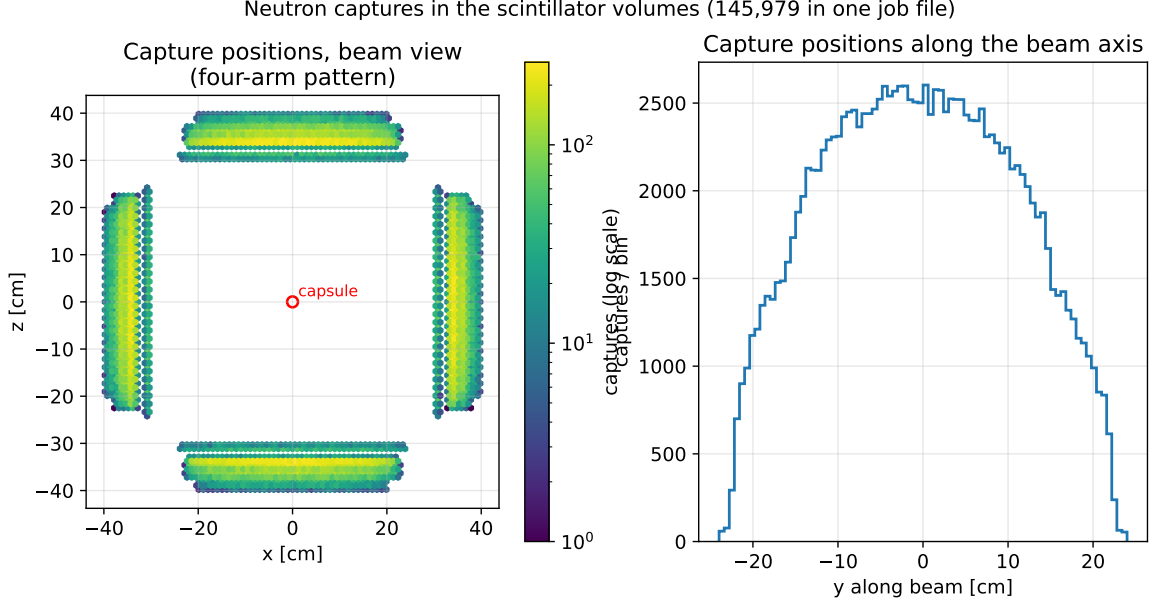
6 Where the neutrons actually end up

A secondary deliverable of run B, relevant for backgrounds rather than signal statistics. Per beam neutron below 1 keV:

fate	per beam neutron	comment
$^3\text{He}(n,p)t$ in gas	7.4×10^{-1}	signal-region heat, no photons
escapes world	2.4×10^{-1}	footprint tail
capture in Al capsule	8.0×10^{-3}	7.7 MeV γ cascades near target
capture in liquid scint.	1.2×10^{-2}	2.2 MeV γ born <i>inside</i> calorimeter
capture in plastic scint.	2.2×10^{-3}	trigger + back layers
capture in CFRP/PCB/mesh	$\sim 1.5 \times 10^{-3}$	distributed
$^3\text{He}(n,\gamma)$	1.0×10^{-8}	the X17 channel

Two observations. First, the aluminium capture rate is ~ 60 times the old flat-cap toy estimate — the STEP capsule’s domed tip and thick shoulder put far more Al in the beam. Second, and not in any toy so far: **hydrogen capture in the liquid scintillator is the largest single capture channel outside the gas**, and its 2.22 MeV photon is born *inside* the calorimeter itself. Both feed the wall-background simulation (run C) via the capture-vertex library.

How do beam neutrons end up in detectors 25 cm off to the side? They do not fly there directly — the beam points up, the arms sit sideways. But a neutron is not absorbed on its first encounter with aluminium: it usually just ricochets. Beam-halo neutrons that miss the 20 mm bore strike the thick Al dome, shoulder or valve, scatter to large angles, and then wander through the air. The four arms (each $\sim 40 \times 40$ cm at 22–31 cm) cover a large fraction of the sky as seen from the capsule, and the LAB liquid scintillator is hydrogen-rich — for a slow neutron, hydrogen is both an efficient brake and an efficient absorber. The capture positions confirm this picture: they reproduce the four-arm cross pattern around the capsule.



7 What this means for the experiment

- **Sub-keV ROI:** 1.1×10^{-4} IPC/pulse and 1.4×10^{-3} X17/pulse (at the assumed 2.5%) — a factor ~ 106 below the table. A thermal-only analysis cannot reach the projected significance; scaled naively, $3.0\sigma \rightarrow 0.3\sigma$ over 30 days.
- **The MeV region:** above ~ 100 keV the gas opacity drops below 5% and the thin-target rows of the table become valid; they carry $\sim 98\%$ of all radiative captures. The commented-out 0.2–2 MeV row (5.2×10^{-2} IPC/pulse) looks like the right anchor. Moving there requires (a) energy-dependent pair kinematics in the generator ($E^* \approx 20.58 \text{ MeV} + \frac{3}{4}E_n$ plus a centre-of-mass boost), and (b) an assessment of the gamma flash and TOF window at μs timescales. Run B-full (1 meV–100 MeV) is on disk to quantify the capture budget there.
- **For discussion with Alberto:** which rows anchored the sensitivity; the provenance of the IPC coefficient (2.1×10^{-3} — multipolarity, E0 contribution); and the capsule-geometry update (the table assumed a 4 cm sphere).

Caveats

- **Statistics:** this draft uses 40 of 100 run-B jobs; the remaining 60 are in production (quota-related corruption, resubmitted). All conclusions rest on the 2.9×10^8 -event (n,p) sample and are insensitive to the final factor 2.5.
- The G4NDL ${}^3\text{He}(n,\gamma)$ strength is validated here only at the $\sim 50\%$ level (4 events); the branching-ratio argument does not depend on it.
- Room-return neutrons and upstream beamline structures are not in the simulation; they affect backgrounds, not the signal-rate conclusion.
- The simulated radial profile and flux are the evaluated Phase-3 EAR2 ones; if the beam group provides updated halo measurements, the footprint losses (24% escape) could shift.

A Row-by-row comparison with the rate table

Radiative captures per *beam* neutron, per energy decade. “Table” reproduces `results_3He` (thin-target); “ceiling” is Eq. (3) corrected for the (n,p) opacity within the decade; “simulation” is the (n,p)×BR measurement from 4×10^8 neutrons (statistical errors negligible); “direct” are the raw $^3\text{He}(n,\gamma)$ counts.

E_n range	table	simulation	table/sim	ceiling	direct counts
1–10 meV	—	6.9×10^{-9}	—	—	0
10–100 meV	1.41×10^{-6}	6.8×10^{-9}	207	1.01×10^{-8}	2
0.1–1 eV	5.71×10^{-7}	7.7×10^{-9}	74	1.01×10^{-8}	0
1–10 eV	1.68×10^{-7}	8.2×10^{-9}	21	1.01×10^{-8}	0
10–100 eV	6.69×10^{-8}	8.1×10^{-9}	8.3	1.00×10^{-8}	0
0.1–1 keV	5.90×10^{-8}	7.5×10^{-9}	7.9	7.9×10^{-9}	2

The simulation sits 20–30% *below* the ceiling because the ceiling assumes every beam neutron is absorbed in the gas, while in reality 67–81% are (footprint tail and window transmission) — visible in the (n,p) column of the per-decade scan output. Flux-weighted over the full sub-keV window the table gives 1.21×10^{-2} IPC/pulse against the simulation’s 1.14×10^{-4} : **factor 106**.

B The four direct events, and provenance

E_n	absorption depth along beam axis
12.4 meV	−29.2 mm (at the entrance face)
13.5 meV	−29.3 mm (at the entrance face)
478 eV	+4.9 mm (mid-column)
519 eV	−22.9 mm

Data: run B sub-keV, 40 validated jobs (4×10^8 neutrons),
`/eos/experiment/ntof/data/x17/full_sim/neutrons_subkev/`.
Scan: `scripts/analyze_thermal_captures.py` → `thermal_captures_subkev_prelim.npz/json`.
Figures: `scripts/make_thermal_report_figures.py`. Repository: `MX17_Full_Geant`, branch `main`.